

# READY

Or are they rendered immobile by the pervasive corruption in society?

The normal perception of the youth today is that of an apathetic generation too preoccupied with a yuppie lifestyle to care about society at large. But the fact is that every generation is a product of the society it lives in. The young today are apathetic because they are in despair. They feel helpless and lost in the red tapism of the bureaucratic system of our country.

Seventy per cent of India's population is under 35 and looking for an escape route. They find this in their alternative lifestyles that are a far cry from the uncivil society that we have become a part of. Now when I look back at the years that I spent growing up in Mumbai, I know for certain that society was a better place, there was less of petty crime and more of a social structure. Society now is regressive and corrupt, and it is natural for the youth to be angry and

upset about it. Everyone is looking for change, but as individuals, all of us go through the feeling of wanting things but not being able to get them.

I would love to vote but cannot, as I am not an Indian citizen. I was born in the US, but I try to make a difference in places where I can. For example, I am trying to motivate young voters, and in doing so I have come across a lot of young people who are angry and upset about the state of affairs. They do want to bring about change but don't know how to. They could have started with the simple option of being more conscious of selecting their leaders, but they feel their voices are bound to get lost in all the political rhetoric. Therefore, they opt out of being a part of the same structure.

The question that is bound to arise is, if the young want change, why don't they choose it? Why aren't they more proactive in choosing their leaders? The answer is simple, politics today has become a dirty word, the options between leaders are minimal. It is no longer the question of who do you want to lead you, but of who is the lesser evil. I, as an individual, try to help in channelising change. For example, did you know that according to Section 49 (O) of the Conduct of Election Rules Act of 1969, our Constitution guarantees that a person can go to the polling booth, confirm his identity, get his finger marked and convey to the presiding election officer that he doesn't want to vote for anyone. Such a feature is available, but obviously the leaders have never disclosed it for their own vested interests.

Making people aware of this can bring in an element of hope for them and I am trying like others, to reach out to the youth in order to understand the level of their disillusionment. In a way, this has resulted in a little bit of change; there are at least 30 million first-time voters this year. It just goes to prove that the generation is awakening. They now know that it can take anyone to be a catalyst for change and that if they keep at it, a better system will evolve.



QAMAR SIBTAIN



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IMRAN KHAN,  
ACTOR, 26